

Fat Loss and Weight Management

Fat Loss

Fat loss requires a sustained calorie deficit over time.

A calorie deficit means average energy intake is lower than average energy expenditure.

No specific normal food burns body fat by itself.

No supplement replaces the need for an appropriate energy balance.

Preserving Lean Mass

During fat loss, useful strategies include:

- resistance training;
- sufficient protein;
- avoiding unnecessarily extreme calorie restriction;
- maintaining sleep and recovery;
- consuming enough carbohydrate to support training.

A commonly useful protein range for healthy exercising adults is approximately:

1.2-2.0 g/kg/day.

Higher protein intake within this range can be particularly useful during calorie restriction for people who train regularly.

Satiety

Foods that can support fullness include:

- vegetables;
- whole fruits;
- legumes;
- lean protein;
- potatoes;
- oats;
- curd or yogurt;
- high-fibre whole grains.

Useful meal-planning strategies include:

- regular meal structure;
- consuming protein at meals;
- choosing high-fibre foods;
- portioning calorie-dense snacks;

- planning meals before becoming extremely hungry;
- being mindful of calorie-containing drinks.

Spot Reduction

Exercise cannot reliably choose where body fat is lost.

Abdominal exercises can strengthen abdominal muscles, but they do not specifically remove abdominal fat.

Rate of Weight Loss

Faster weight loss is not automatically better.

Aggressive dieting can increase:

- hunger;
- fatigue;
- loss of training performance;
- lean-tissue loss;
- difficulty adhering to the diet.

Sustainable approaches are generally easier to maintain.

Weight Maintenance

Weight maintenance is not one exact calorie number.

Body weight normally fluctuates within a range because of:

- water;
- sodium;
- carbohydrate intake;
- glycogen;
- bowel contents;
- hormonal changes;
- training-related inflammation.

Useful maintenance habits include:

- consistent meal patterns;
- regular protein intake;
- fruits and vegetables;
- sufficient fibre;
- routine physical activity;
- flexible inclusion of enjoyable foods;

- periodic monitoring if desired.

Example Vegetarian Fat-Loss Meal Structure

Breakfast

- oats or vegetable poha;
- curd or another protein source;
- fruit.

Lunch

- moderate portion of rice or roti;
- dal;
- tofu or paneer;
- a large serving of vegetables.

Snack

- fruit;
- yogurt or roasted chickpeas.

Dinner

- protein-rich dal, tofu or paneer meal;
- vegetables;
- moderate grain portion.

Example Non-Vegetarian Fat-Loss Meal Structure

Breakfast

- eggs;
- whole-grain food;
- fruit.

Lunch

- chicken or fish;
- rice or roti in an appropriate portion;
- vegetables;
- dal if desired.

Snack

- curd or yogurt;
- fruit.

Dinner

- lean protein;
- vegetables;
- moderate carbohydrate portion.

Common Fat-Loss Misconceptions

Carbohydrates automatically cause fat gain

Body-fat gain is primarily related to sustained excess energy intake.

Sweating more means more body fat was burned

Sweat is primarily a cooling mechanism. Short-term weight loss from sweating is mostly fluid.

A single food causes belly fat

Body-fat distribution is influenced by total energy balance, genetics and other factors.

Detox products are necessary for weight loss

Detox teas and cleanses are not required for fat loss and can cause dehydration or gastrointestinal problems.